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Rolling the Dice

Aristotle would have loved the casinos. They are a perfect example of a modern day Aristotelian tragedy. Every player experiences the five stages of a tragedy much like Oedipus Rex did. These five steps, which are defined later using Aristotle's *The Poetics*, are hamartia, pathos, peripeteia, anagnorisis, and purification. Every casino player experiences these five steps which makes them the perfect example of a modern day Oedipus and Aristotelian tragedy.

First, it is necessary to define the five terms in the order they are presented in an Aristotelian tragedy. After, an example of each term will be illustrated with an excerpt from the famously written play: *Oedipus Rex* written by Sophocles. Then it will be easy to connect how a casino player is a perfect example of a modern day Aristotelian tragedy.

The first step and term is hamartia. Hamartia is the ignorance of a particular fact or facts that causes a tragic flaw in a character. Aristotle phrased this differently in *The Poetics* he said "Hamartia, then, includes errors made in ignorance or through misjudgement; but it will also include moral errors of a kind which do not imply wickedness." (Aristotle 17). For instance, Oedipus is ignorant of his birth parents which

sets in motion his tragic flaw. Teiresias illustrates this concept best when he reacts to Oedipus' outburst regarding Teiresias being a blind prophet: "you have your eyesight, and you do not see\ how miserable you are, or where you live,\ or who it is who shares your household.\ Do you know the family you come from? Without your knowledge you've become\ the enemy of your own kindred" (Sophocles 11). Oedipus' ignorance of his birth lineage led to the sinful act of killing his father and having offspring with his mother. Ignorance of a particular fact can cause a hefty loss or cost to someone just like Oedipus.

Moreover, the second step and term is pathos. Pathos is a tragic and destructive act based off a tragic flaw. Aristotle defines pathos as "an action [praxis] that involves destruction or pain" (Aristotle 11). Due to Oedipus' hamartia, he murders his father without knowing. For example, when Oedipus is talking to Jocasta about Laius' death she says: "I passed close by\ a spot where three roads meet, and in that place\ I met a herald and a horse-drawn carriage.\ Inside there was a man like you described\...I hit him a quick blow with the staff I held\and knocked him from his carriage to the road.\ He lay there on his back. Then I killed them all"(Sophocles 21). Oedipus unknowingly killed his father because he had already experienced hamartia. Lack of knowledge cascades into a detrimental behavior, and in Oedipus' case, it led him to bet he was the murderer of his own father.

Furthermore, the third step and term is peripeteia. Peripeteia is a sudden reversal of fortune or change in circumstances. Aristotle explains this term as "a change to the opposite in the actions being performed" (Aristotle 16). Oedipus experiences peripeteia

when Jocasta commits suicide: “Then we saw her./She was hanging there, swaying, with twisted cords/roped round her neck. When Oedipus saw her,/ with a dreadful groan he took her body/out of the noose in which she hung” (Sophocles 33). Prior to pathos, Oedipus lived a fortunate life in ignorance of his own sin, but after pathos he experienced a shift in circumstances leading to his inevitable loss of his eyes and in Jocasta’s case, her eyes. Peripeteia can change fortunate situations to unfortunate ones suddenly.

Additionally, the fourth step and term is anagnorisis. Anagnorisis is the discovery of an ignorance or the sudden recognition or realization. Aristotle writes that it “is 'a change from ignorance to knowledge'” (Aristotle 16). For instance, Jocasta discovered the prophecy had come true and finally learned that her husband was also her son. After calling for the messenger she runs into the palace after telling Oedipus “In the name of the gods, no! If you have\ some concern for your own life, then stop!\ Do not keep investigating this.\ I will suffer—that will be enough” (Sophocles 28). In this moment she discovered who Oedipus truly was and she tried to prevent him from discovering the truth. In a tragedy, everyone has a sudden recognition of their ignorance and this step is vital to correcting that ignorance.

Lastly, the fifth step and term is catharsis. Catharsis is the purification and purgation of emotions. Aristotle defines this last step as “pleasurable relief” (Aristotle 20). For example, this occurs when Oedipus blinds himself: “from her clothes he ripped the golden brooches\ she wore as ornaments, raised them high,\ and drove them deep into his eyeballs,\ crying as he did so: "You will no longer see\ all those atrocious things I suffered,\ the dreadful things I did” (Sophocles 33). Oedipus blinding himself

was his cathartic purification from murdering his own father and sleeping with his mother. Even though Oedipus could see he was blind to his fatal flaw and that ignorance led to his downfall. Catharsis cleanses a person's fatal flaw.

The five steps Oedipus experienced are the five steps every casino player experiences. First it must be understood that the house has an edge over every player who plays. This edge is predicated off highly studied probabilities and statistics. It is necessary for Casinos to make money to continue running the establishment. Therefore, the house is granted an edge in every game to fulfill that need. However, this fact is most casino player's hamartia.

Each player is ignorant to the edge and will often play anyway thinking they will win money. This may be true for some people; however, this is usually not the case for everyone. By continuing to play and gamble money, each player is entering into a state of pathos. They are destructively losing their money because they are blinded to the house edge. They may win at first or at random times, but most players will soon experience a reversal of their luck or what is also called peripetia.

A player will eventually lose money the more play not realizing it is a slim chance to be a winner. After their fortune runs out and they have less money than when they entered, they will enter into the fourth step: anagnorsis. Once the player realizes the house has an edge it will be too late because they've lost all their money. The player will soon realize the edge led to their destruction when they cleansed or purified of their money and will regret their actions.

Overall it is clear that every casino player is like a modern day Aristotelian tragedy. Casino players experience the five stages of an Aristotelian tragedy much like Oedipus did. It is necessary to compare our present situations from past ones to learn from them. Oedipus could not avoid his fatal end, but we can. New insight to these unnecessary indulgences can prevent modern day Oedipus' and Aristotelian tragedies. A modern day Aristotelian tragedy is like rolling the dice at a casino: you might win, and you might lose.